

AI Readiness Reflection

A self-reflection prompt for partners and principals of regulated Australian small firms.

Free document. No email required. Use it alone, with your partners, or in a brief leadership conversation. The point is not to score yourself; it is to surface what you can and cannot currently answer.

What this is

This document lays out the kinds of questions I would ask if you booked a paid AI Readiness Diagnostic with borck.consulting. The structure follows the five strategic questions used in the Diagnostic itself (Can / Should / How / Are / What's the Value), drawn from the AI strategy literature (Upadhyay, *Artificial Intelligence for Managers*, 2021; Yao & Koidan, *Applied Artificial Intelligence*, 2024) and applied with the *Conversation not Delegation* framework as the operating principle.

Reading this is not a substitute for the Diagnostic conversation, but working through the questions honestly will tell you something useful about where the firm stands, regardless of whether you and I ever speak.

Allow yourself thirty to sixty minutes. Write your answers rather than think them; written answers expose gaps that mental ones do not.

There is a closing section called *What your answers tell you*. Read it after you have worked through the five sections, not before.

What this is not

This is not a self-scoring assessment. There is no number at the end. The work is in the answering, and what you do with the answers depends on what they reveal, which is precisely the part a generic document cannot do for you.

This is also not a sales document for the paid Diagnostic. Some readers will work through this and conclude they have answers; that is a useful conclusion and you do not need to engage me further. Others will find the answers harder than they expected; that is also a useful conclusion, and the paid Diagnostic exists for that case.

1. Can we do AI? Capability and current state

The first question is whether the firm is currently equipped to use AI well. Not whether AI is permitted; whether the firm's actual capability, across people, data, infrastructure, and culture, supports the use it has already begun.

1.1 List every AI tool the firm currently pays for, by name. Include personal accounts that staff use for work, even if the firm does not pay for them. If you cannot list these confidently, that is itself an answer.

1.2 Take three of those tools in turn. For each, write down: who in the firm uses it, how often, and what for. Use specific examples: *"Sarah uses ChatGPT to redraft client replies, two or three times a week"* is a different quality of answer than *"people use it sometimes."*

1.3 Identify the staff members in the firm you would describe as habitual or capable AI users. Write their names. Then write the staff members who do not use AI at all, by your understanding. If both groups are smaller than your total headcount, what is the third group doing?

1.4 Where do you think AI is being used in the firm that you do not currently see? Almost every firm has an answer; the answer matters.

1.5 Could the firm currently sustain AI use that it considered important, not just tolerate it, but actively support it with training, guidance, and an internal owner? Or would such use depend on individual initiative?

2. Should we do AI? Opportunity and risk

The second question is whether the firm should be using AI in the ways it currently is, and where AI would create defensible value rather than expose the firm to risks that exceed the value.

2.1 Where in the firm's work would AI most plausibly add value if used well? Be specific: not "drafting" but "first-pass drafts of standard property contract clauses where the senior associate's review remains the binding step."

2.2 Where would AI introduce risks that exceed the value? Same level of specificity: not "data leakage" but "the property associates pasting client emails into ChatGPT to draft replies."

2.3 What's the most sensitive material your team handles in a typical week? In a typical month? In a typical year? For each, can you currently say with confidence whether it has, or has not, passed through any AI tool?

2.4 Imagine the relevant Australian regulator for your sector (the Legal Practice Board of WA, the relevant Health Practitioner Regulation Agency, the Tax Practitioners Board, ASIC) asked you tomorrow how the firm uses AI. Write the answer you would give them in plain English, in three or four sentences. Read it back. Would it satisfy you, in their position?

2.5 Has any client raised the topic of AI with the firm, whether asking that you use it, asking that you do not, or asking how you handle their material? If so, what did you tell them? If not, do you expect this to happen in the next twelve months?

3. How would we do AI? Implementation orientation

The third question is what the firm would actually do, in what order. It distinguishes “we should think about this” from “this is the next move.”

3.1 Has the firm tried any AI training, formal or informal? Who attended? What changed afterwards?

3.2 Has the firm written any kind of AI use policy or internal guideline, even a one-page memo? If yes, where does it live, when was it last updated, and what does the staff actually do in light of it?

3.3 Is there an internal owner of AI in the firm: a person staff would naturally go to with the question “*is this appropriate?*” If yes, name them; if no, write down what currently happens when a staff member has the question.

3.4 If the firm decided this week to take AI more seriously, what would the first move be? Workshop, policy, infrastructure change, hire? Why that one, and not the others?

3.5 Where have efforts to address this stalled? What is the actual blocker: partner buy-in, IT capacity, competing priorities, lack of clarity, lack of internal authority, something else?

4. Are we ready? Readiness check

The fourth question is whether the firm has the foundation (data, technology, people) to act on the move it would choose.

4.1 Where does the firm’s important written knowledge currently live? Document management system, shared drives, email, individuals’ inboxes, paper? Is it organised, searchable, and accessible to staff who would need it?

4.2 What technology does the firm currently use that AI tools would need to integrate with (practice management systems, document management, accounting software, billing)? Are any of those locked or constrained in ways that would limit AI integration?

4.3 If the firm wanted to bring sensitive matters into AI workflows without sending data to cloud services, does it have anyone, internally or in its trusted network, who would know how to evaluate or implement local AI infrastructure? If not, what's the plan?

4.4 Does the firm have the capacity, in terms of people-time, to absorb a meaningful change in how it works with AI in the next six to twelve months? Or is the team already at capacity for any new initiative?

5. What's the value? Business case framing

The fifth question is what the work would be worth, in the firm's own terms.

5.1 If the firm closed its AI literacy gap in the next six months, what would change in concrete terms? Time saved on what; quality improved on what; risk reduced on what?

5.2 If the firm wrote and operated a real AI use policy in the next twelve months, what would be the value? Be specific about the value, not the policy itself.

5.3 If a client questionnaire arrived next month asking how the firm handles AI in client material, what is the answer worth, currently? What would it be worth if the firm had a confident answer?

5.4 What would it cost the firm, in time and money, *not* to act on this in the next twelve months? Often the right business case for AI work is the cost of inaction, not the return on action.

5.5 What investment range would the firm be prepared to consider for this work, if the case were clear? Tens of thousands? Six figures? Be honest with yourself about what the firm would and would not approve.

What your answers tell you

Read this section *after* you have worked through the five above. Reading it first will change how you answer.

If you found you could answer most of these questions confidently and specifically, the firm has done more thinking on this than most. The remaining work for you is probably about consolidation: pulling the partial positions you have arrived at into a clear written framework, and addressing the few areas that you noticed surface as you wrote. You may not need a paid Diagnostic. You may benefit from a workshop that crystallises what the firm already knows into a shared vocabulary, or from a governance engagement that turns your existing position into a written policy. Both are described on borck.consulting/services.

If you found that around half of your answers were vague, generic, or uncertain, the firm is in the most common state: adopting AI without a deliberate position, with awareness uneven across staff, with no shared language for what good use looks like. This is the position a paid AI Readiness Diagnostic exists to address. Two hours with the leadership team and a written recommendation will identify the highest-leverage first move, which for most firms in this state is closing the literacy gap before any policy is written.

If you found that most of your answers were uncertain or that several of the questions surprised you, the firm has not yet formed a position on AI use, and the staff position is whatever individuals have decided. This is not unusual and it is not a crisis, but it is the state in which exposure accumulates fastest. The work is to form a deliberate position, and it begins with a structured conversation rather than a policy document. A paid Diagnostic is designed exactly for this case.

If you found yourself wanting to discuss specific answers, not because you do not know them, but because writing them down has produced new questions, that is itself a useful signal. The Diagnostic conversation is in part a structured way of doing the same reflection with a counterpart who can name the patterns and the alternatives.

About this document and the practice

This document is a reflection prompt, not a diagnostic. The paid AI Readiness Diagnostic (a two-hour structured conversation with the leadership team and a 2–3 page written recommendation) does work this document cannot: it draws specific findings out of conversation, places the firm on each of the five questions in the firm's own terms, and produces a recommendation tied to the specific firm rather than firms in general.

The methodology behind both this reflection and the paid Diagnostic is structured around the five strategic questions used in *Artificial Intelligence for Managers* (Upadhyay, 2021) and *Applied Artificial Intelligence* (Yao & Koidan, 2024). The framework I work from is *Conversation not Delegation*, articulated across two of my books, *Conversation not Delegation* and *Partner Don't Police*, adopted onto the reading list at Kaplan Business School after an external interview on AI use in education. Both books, along with the rest of my seven-book catalogue, are free to download under CC BY-SA 4.0 (content) and MIT (code, in the technical books) at books.borck.education; each comes with a companion chatbot, a navigable wiki, and GitHub access to source material. The framework's core distinction is between using AI as a delegate and using it as a collaborator. Most AI failures in professional services are failures of this distinction at the team level, before they are failures of technology or policy.

The practice serves regulated Australian small firms: law, medical and allied-health, accounting, financial-advisory. Engagements are fixed-scope and fixed-price. The data-handling commitment that applies to my paid work also applies to anyone who uses this document or contacts the practice: I do not store your reflection answers, I do not have access to them, and there is no email capture on the download.

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